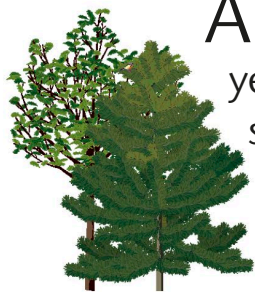


How a forest forms



A forest does not appear overnight. It takes years, sometimes centuries, before tiny seedlings grow into tall, majestic trees. Just like humans, a forest starts small, then grows and develops through many different stages. This is called “succession.”

Events such as fires, storms, flooding, and logging can severely delay forest succession.

Bare ground

Everything starts with a firm base—in a forest’s case, this means a patch of bare ground.

Herbs, grasses, and ferns

Bare ground is just what short, grassy plants like to grow in. Once grasses start to grow, tougher and taller plants such as herbs move in, and so do some ferns, such as bracken.

Shrubland

After several years, taller, thicker-stemmed shrubs start to grow. They crowd out the grasses and other plants. Some of these shrubs include small trees, which eventually grow taller than the rest of the plants.

